MODULE 8
Finding First Users
From Zero to Your First 10 Paying Customers

ASSIGNMENT: Get your first paying customer (even if just 1 Euro)

A joint initiative by

Check-In:

How much new revenue did you sign?

Check-In:

The Outcome - Go, Pivot, or Kill?

Today

Check-in — GPK verdicts CONFIRMED + prototype numbers (15')

IDEA 1 · Do things that don't scale (10')

IDEA 2 · Ten specific humans (10')

IDEA 3 · Founder-led sales: volume, then craft (15')

IDEA 4 · The first euro (10')

Case · Stripe: the Collison installation (30')

Workshop · The Collison Installation — 10 messages sent LIVE (90')

Check-In:

The Learning - What did you decide? What's the #1 thing you learned?

RECAP: From Module 7

1. You ran a pre-mortem and identified your biggest risks
2. You tested your hardest assumption with the monkey-first approach
3. Today: We find real customers who will PAY for your solution

'Do things that don't scale' — Paul Graham, Y Combinator

IDEA 1: Do things that don't scale

At n<100 users, hand-to-hand beats every scalable channel. Install it for them. Deliver it yourself.

Scalable comes later — first, someone must want it at all. (Graham 2013, the most important essay in startups.)

Killed last week? You still sell today

The concierge offer: deliver the OUTCOME as a service — zero product required.

DoorDash's founders delivered the food themselves. Your restart-ramp team pitches its concierge in this workshop like everyone else.

A restart that banks a euro by Demo Day beats a zombie that never asked.

IDEA 2: Ten specific humans

If you can't NAME ten people who need this, you have a fantasy, not a market.

Your M06 outreach list is the raw material — today we upgrade it: real pain AND budget authority.

IDEA 3: Founder-led sales

Every funnel step loses ~90% — so the top needs volume: 50–100 touches per handful of meetings, not 10.

Nobody closes your first customers but you. It's a conversation, not a pitch.

A joint initiative by

Excerpt: Why Churn is slowly killing you

Assumptions:
Sign-ups: 100
Conversion Rate: 20%
Churn Rate: 10%

Sign-Ups	Conversions	Total Customers	Churn
100	0	0	0
100	20	20	2
100	20	38	4
100	20	54	6
100	20	68	7
…	…	…	…
100	20	190	19
100	20	191	20

Churn is your mathematical limit to growth.

Long term, reducing Churn (improving CLT), is your way to better serving your market!

Row 33 (under these assumptions)

IDEA 4: The first euro

The first outside-euro matters more than any milestone before it — it converts a project into a company.

Ask at a real pilot price (€300–500 anchors). The €1 favor teaches you nothing and anchors you into hobby territory.

END RECAP — today in four lines

1 · Hand-to-hand beats scalable — for now

2 · Ten named humans with pain AND budget

3 · Volume first: the funnel eats 90% at every step

4 · Ask for real money at a real price — today

This week: first outside-€ (pass) · 3 paying users (stretch). 48h follow-ups on everything.

Workshop: The Collison Installation (90 min)

Agenda lives in M08_Workshop_Collison-Installation.md — target list from your M06 ten, pilot pricing, role-play, then 10 messages SENT live.

Must produce: 10 outreach messages sent + tracking live + objection prep written.

Kill criteria: zero replies in 48 hours across all ten — then the list, the message, or the offer is wrong. We fix it in check-in.

Wrapup & Checkout

Thank You!

A joint initiative by

APPENDIX — original slides (instructor's cut candidates)

Everything below stayed in the deck — moved out of the flow, not deleted. Mark KEEP (returns to flow) or KILL. Only Basti deletes.

Check-In:

What is your Energy Level Today?

Check-In:

How many users did you talk to?

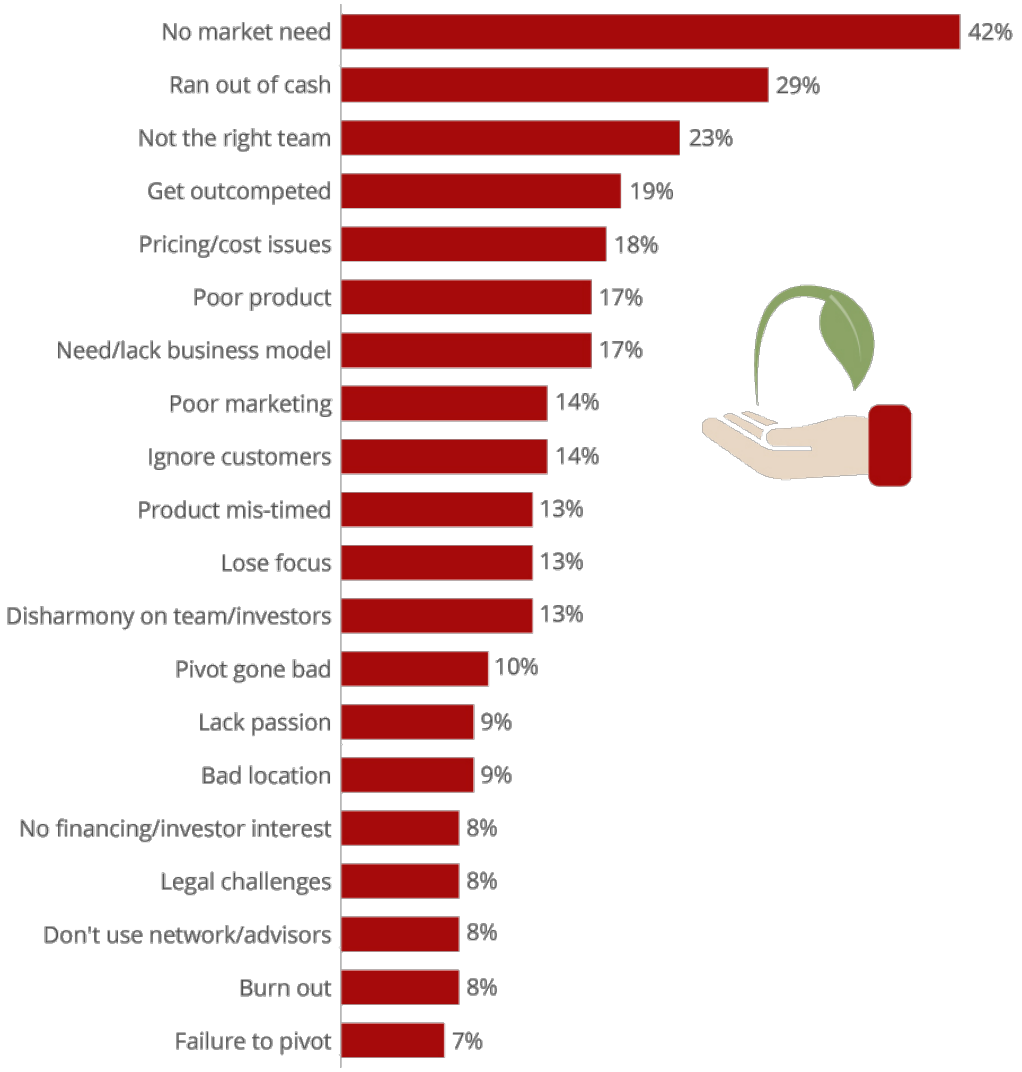
Check-In:

The Next Step - What's your path forward now?

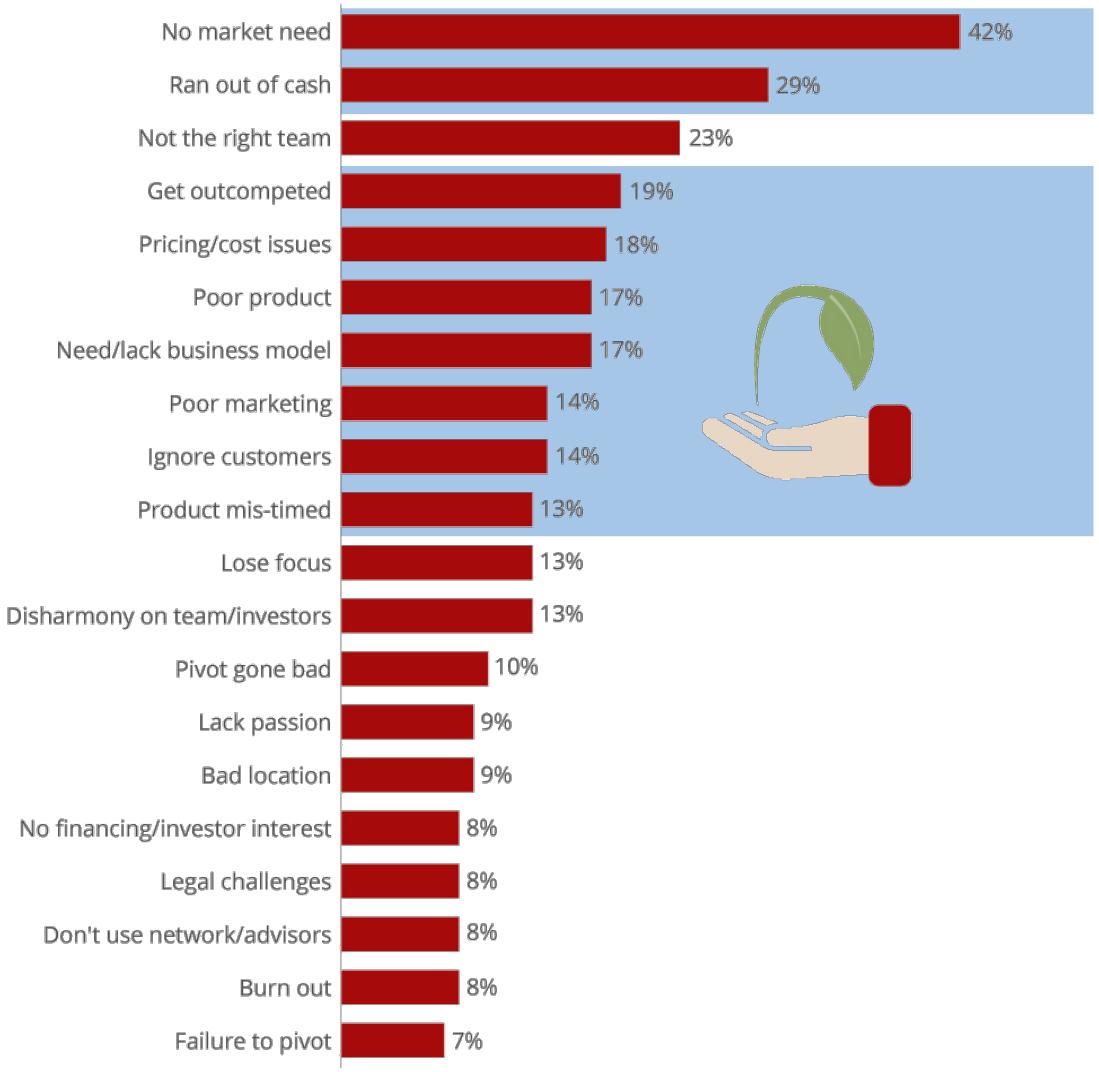
Recap from last time

Let‘s jump in!

Why do startups fail?



Why do startups fail?



Get in touch with users and customers. Learn what it is they need.

Iterate quickly and execute dilligently.

Your typical day on the customer (Ideation & Early Incubation – months 1-6)

	Founder 1	Founder 2	Founder 3
9:00	Co-Founder Alignment	Co-Founder Alignment	Co-Founder Alignment
10:00	Customer Interview	Create Content	Customer Interview
11:00	Customer Interview	Schedule Content	Customer Interview
12:00	Lunch Break	Lunch Break	Lunch Break
13:00	Schedule new Interviews	Engage with Community	Build Product
14:00	Customer Interview	Scan for insights and issues	Build Product
15:00	Customer Interview	Update Landingpage	Build Product
16:00	Customer Interview	Customer Interview	Build Product (Ship)
17:00	Customer Interview	Customer Interview	Document Learnings
18:00	Dinner Break	Dinner Break	Dinner Break
19:00	Joint Learnings	Joint Learnings	Joint Learnings
20:00	Administrative Work	Administrative Work	Administrative Work

Shipping Fast,
Growing Fast,
Learning Fast,

Is a multi-person job

Does this help you learn to make revenue?

Things that keep you out of jail.

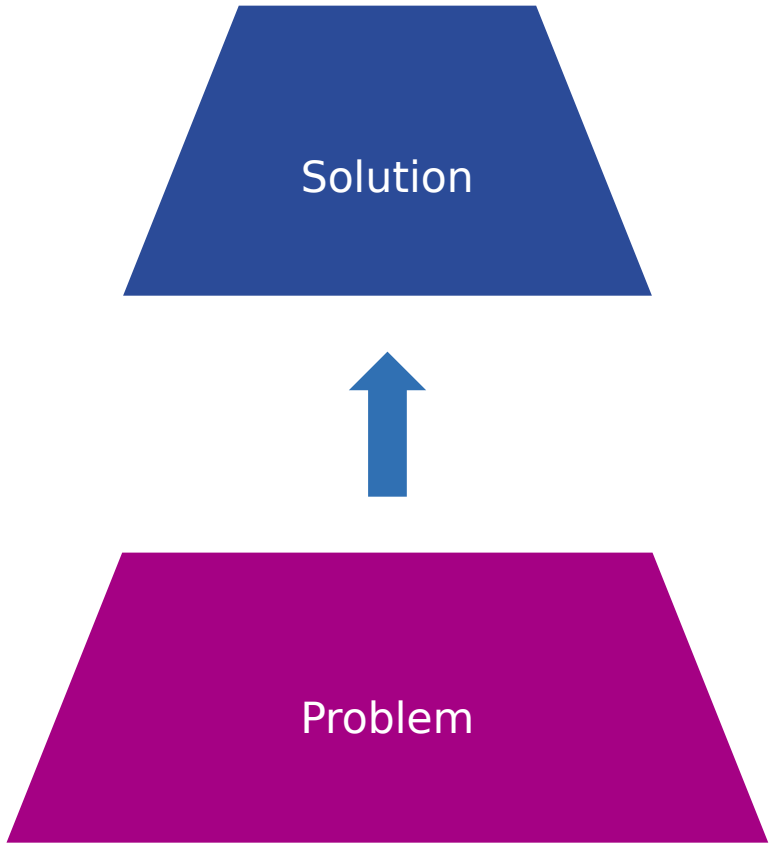
When you start seeing a difference in your pattern

Customer Discovery
You: “I want to understand your problem and context”

Focus: learning, not pitching

Typical questions:

- “How do you do X today?”
- “What goes wrong?”
- “What does that cost you (time, money, stress)?”



Sales Conversation
You: “I think we can help – here’s how”

Focus: matching their problem with your solution + asking for a next step

Still 80% listening, 20% demo/talking

Let‘s talk conversion (1/3)



Example Numbers:

740 25 1

Conversion Rates:

3,4% 4%

Industry Averages:

2-5% 1-3%

Remember: Update these numbers

How many IMPRESSIONS do you need for the desired number of Sign-Ups?

Let‘s talk conversion (1/3)



Example Numbers:

47.060 1.600 64

Conversion Rates:

3,4% 4%

Industry Averages:

2-5% 1-3%

How many IMPRESSIONS do you need for the desired number of Sign-Ups?

Let‘s talk conversion (2/3)



Example Numbers:

64 5 2

Conversion Rates:

7,8% 5%

Industry Averages:

1-10% 3-10%

On each conversion, you loose about **1-2 Orders of magnitude**!!!

Sooo: How make numbers go brrr…?

IMPRESSIONS

- Always be posting
- Improve your targeting
- Improve your relevance

Tool: Posting & Outreach

CLICKS

- Farm your friends & family
- Guide through keynotes & presentations

Tool: Keep the flywheel going

Sign-Ups

- Demos, Interviews, …
- Personal Interaction

Tool: Interviewing Techniques

Customers

- Show attention
- Manage your funnel
- Be their concierge

Tool: Managing your Funnel

Never, never drop the thread!

Reach out on LinkedIn

Go on Landing Page

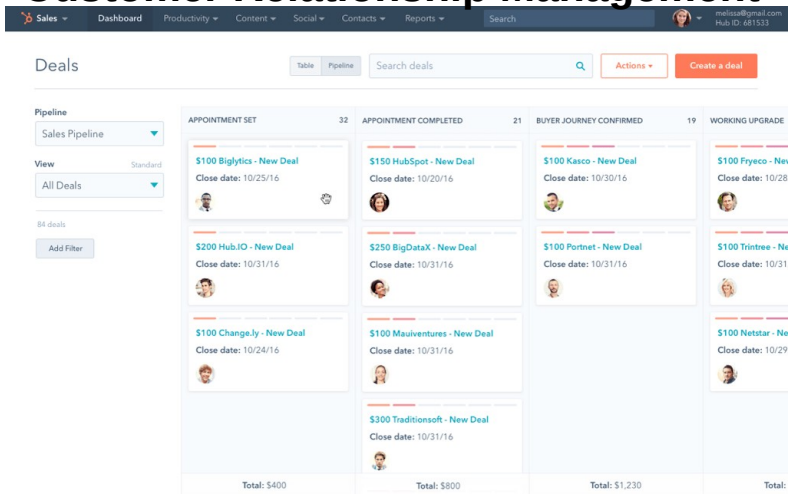
Sign up for Account

Leave Email Address

Schedule a Call via Google Calendar

Get account information

Customer Relationship Management



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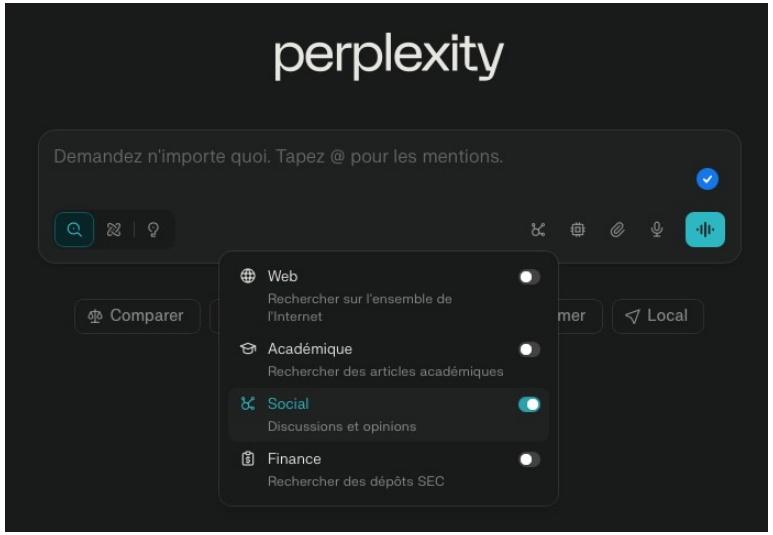
Strategies involving Social Media

Post Yourself:



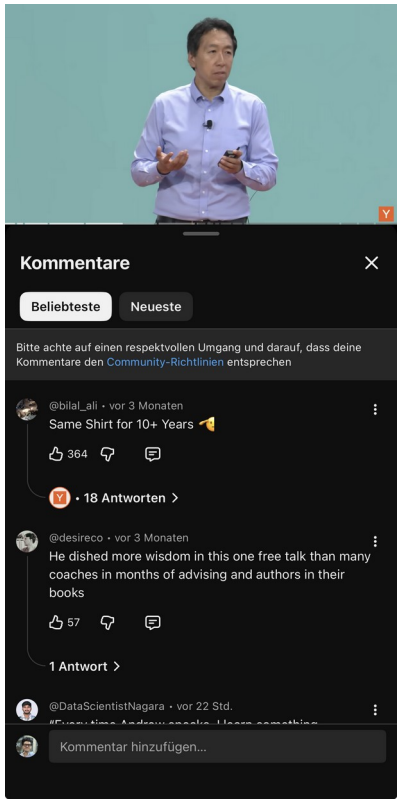
Scheduled job on your recent findings:
Create an engaging LinkedIn/… post

Find the current trend:



Use websearch to find relevant posts
in your area of interest

Like, Comment, & Subscribe:



AI not yet reliable… use your brain to interact
with existing content & communities

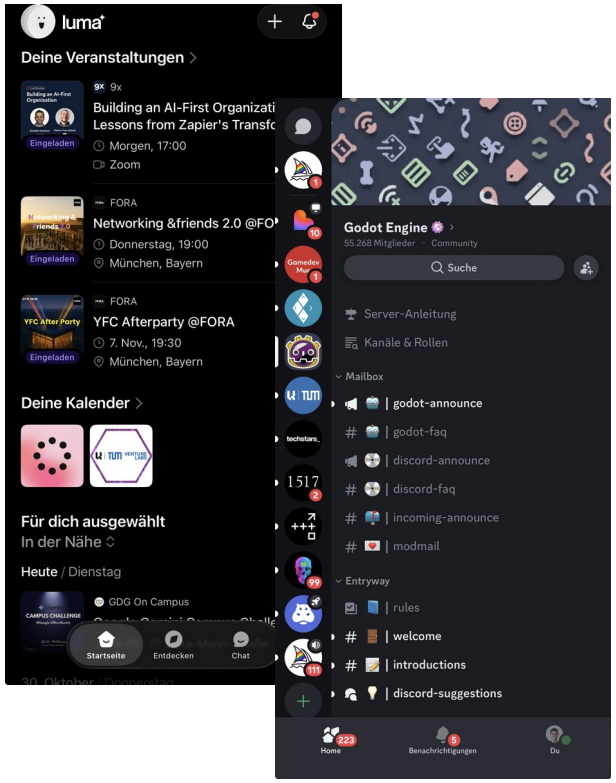
Audiences beyond Social Media

Specialist Media:



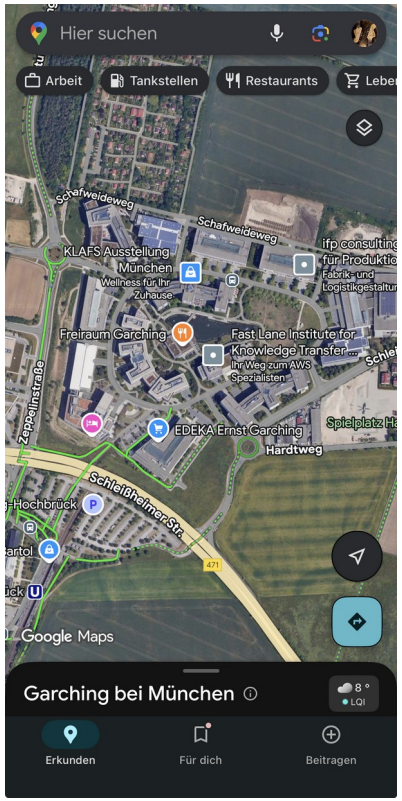
Use Perplexity or an AI search to find specialty media and then buy some of them

Online Communities:



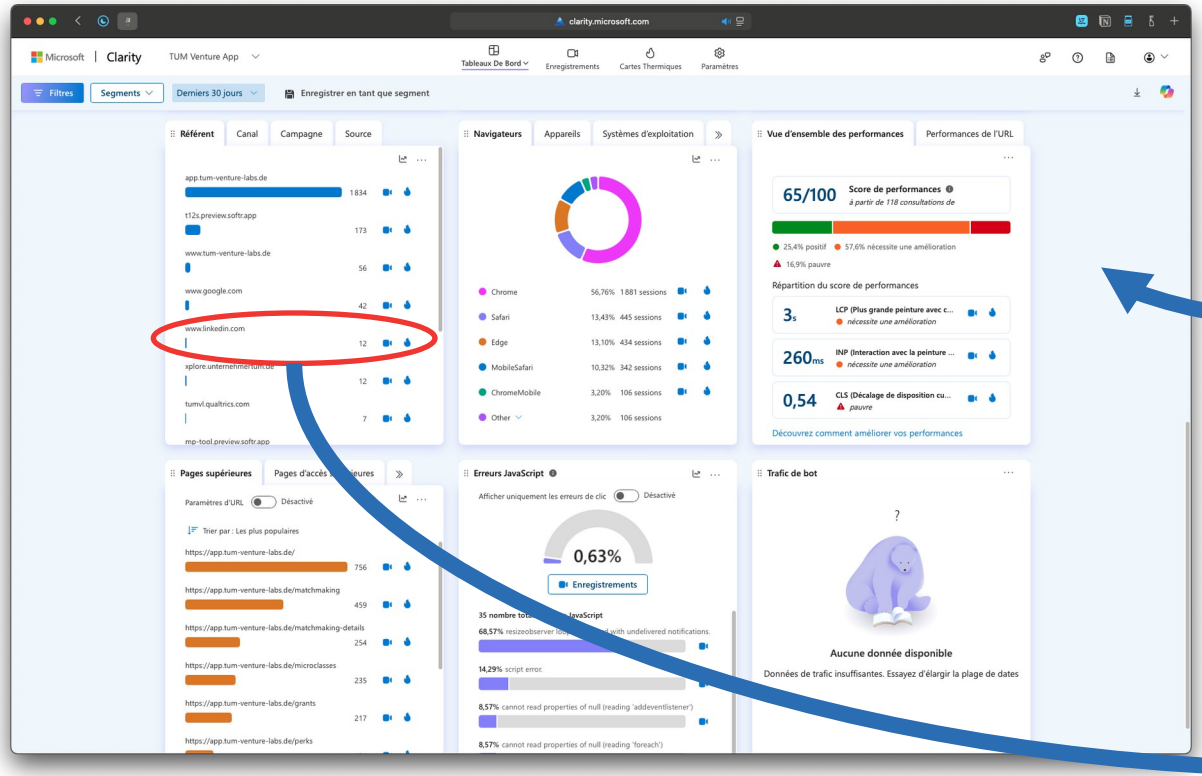
Use Agents (ChatGPT or MCP, schedules) to run on Luma, Eventbride, Meetup, Slack, Discord, WhatsApp

Offline Communities:



AI not yet reliable… use your brain to find hot-spots, offices, hangouts, etc.

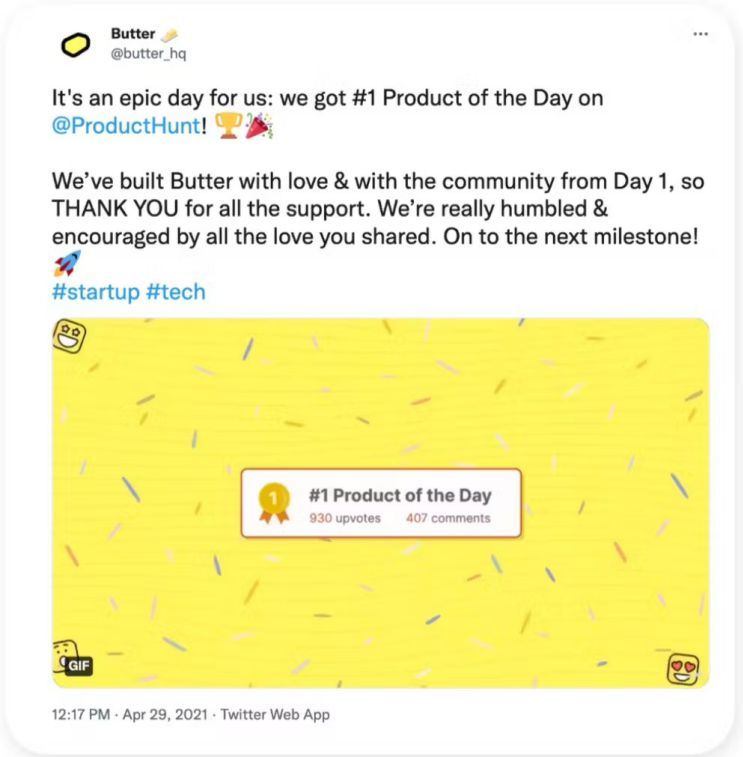
Double Down on what works



Meassure your success

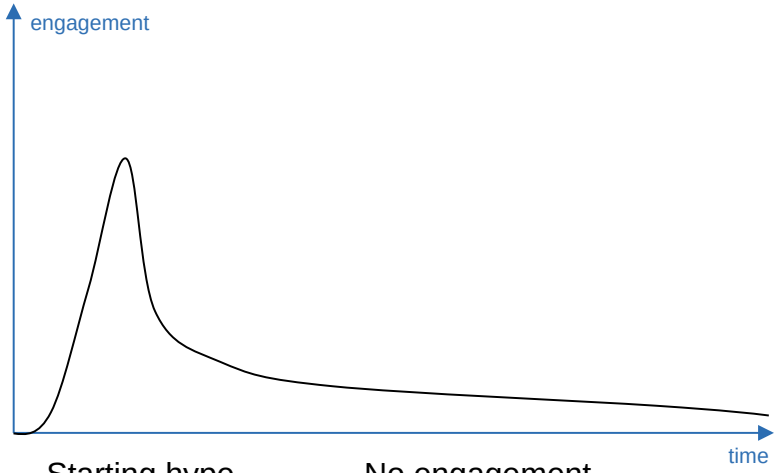
2x the input

> 2x the outcome?



Monitoring engagement in a problem space

Case 1: No Interest

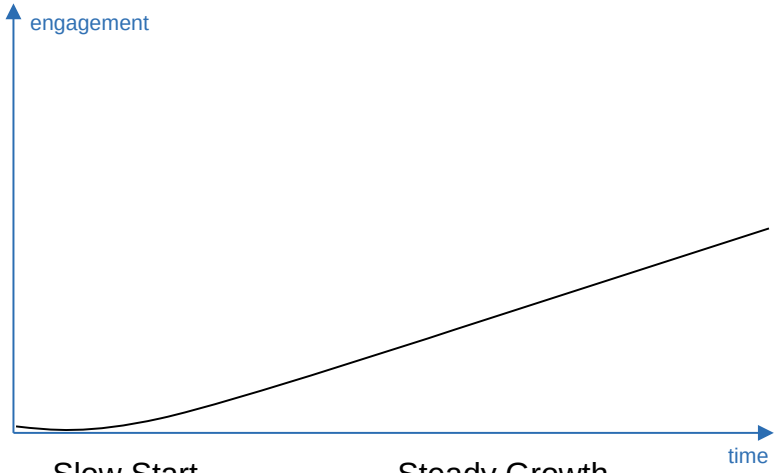


Starting hype — No engagement

Wrong target group/
Wrong problem/
Poor communication

To-Do: Rework Problem Space

Case 1: Organic Interest

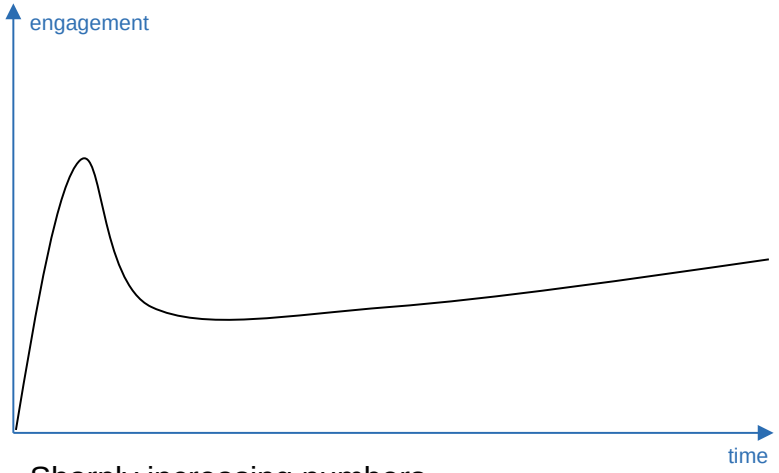


Slow Start — Steady Growth

Right target included/
Sustained interest/
Good communication

To-Do: Identify user group

Artifact: External shock



Sharply increasing numbers

Back to normal on higher level

Newspaper article/
Social media event

You want to look for dx/dt>0 for t>>0

Impressions < Clicks < Sign-ups (Remember Hirarchie of evidence!)

Sooo: How make numbers go brrr…?

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Tool: Posting & Outreach

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- Guide through keynotes & presentations

Tool: Keep the flywheel going

Sign-Ups

- Demos, Interviews, …
- Personal Interaction

Tool: Interviewing Techniques

Customers

- Show attention
- Manage your funnel
- Be their concierge

Tool: Managing your Funnel

How to find customers

Must like your Value Proposition

(Every lecture ever)



Need to have money

(Possess buying power)

Need to be hungry

(Currently feel the pain)

Need to be around

(Be servicable)

+ what else???

(Depending on what you offer)

Start the flywheel and keep it going!

People repost and start talking about you

People hear about you from all over

Don‘t stop! If people stop hearing from you, they immediately will forget.

People think you must be very successful



You post about your successes

Start Small:

- End of Seminar
- First User
- etc…

You win a prize or get media attention

When you need the attention, it‘s way too late to start!

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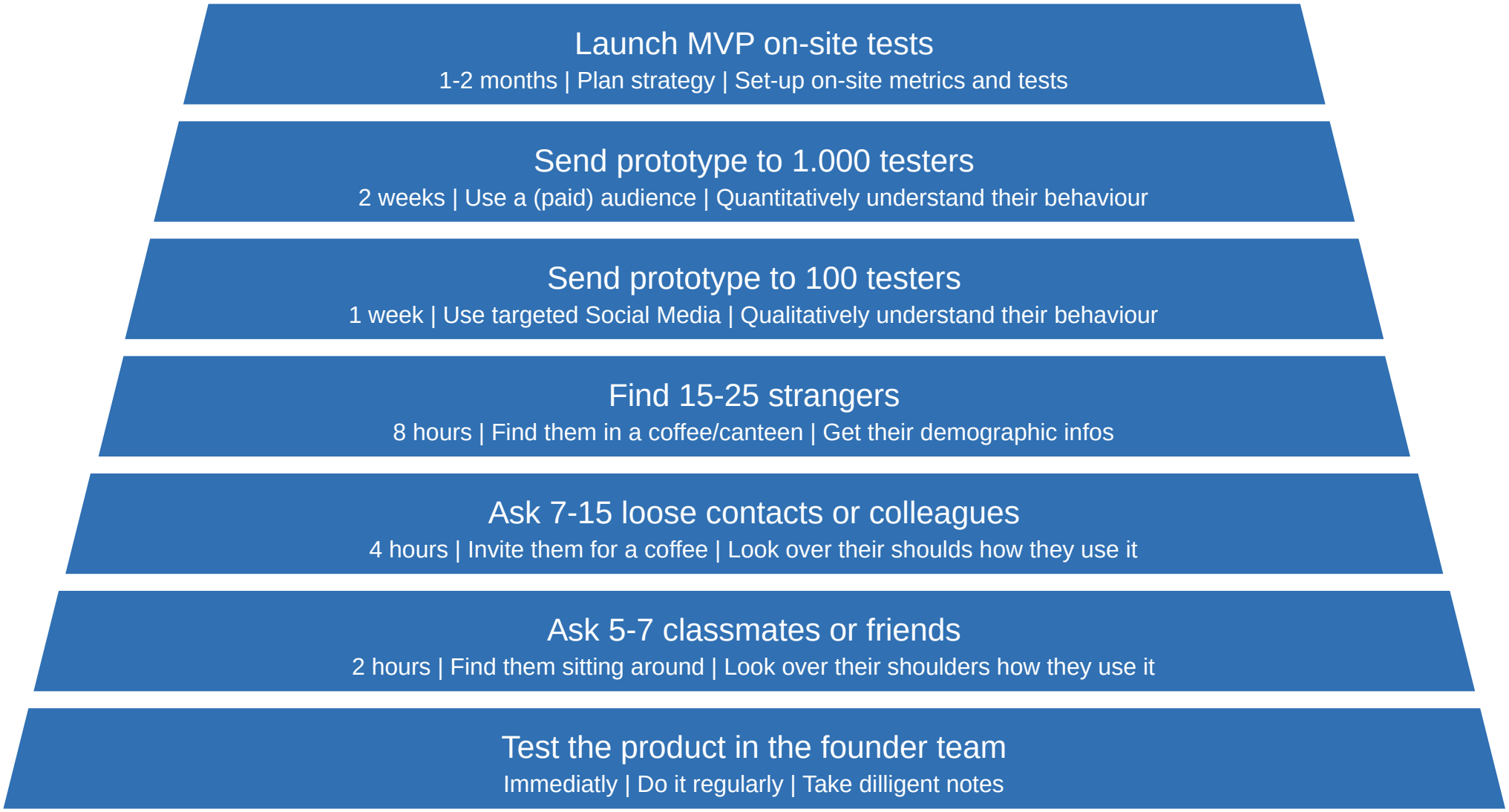
Tool: Interviewing Techniques

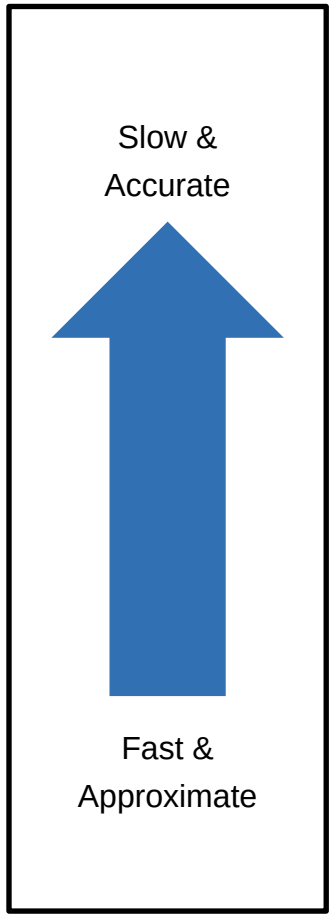
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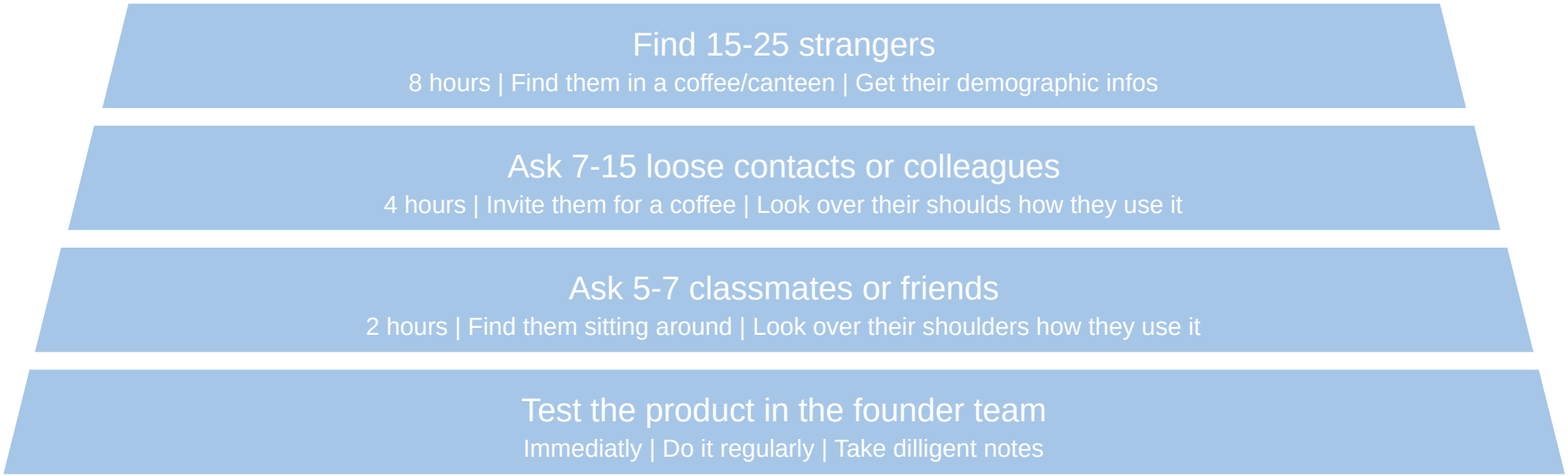
Testing your prototype



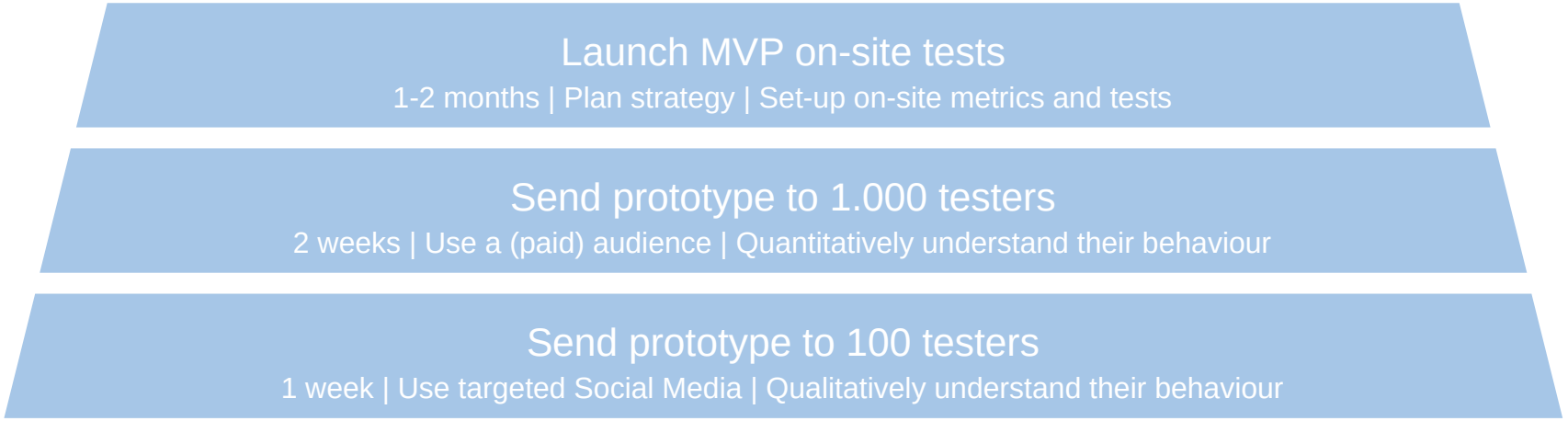


Finding an Audience

- **Better done than perfect:** Use who you can find, even if they are not your perfect customer
- **Know your customers:** B2B goes to canteens, B2C sit in cafees, when do they have 10 mins
- **Give first, take second:** Offer them a beverage or snack for their time
- **Set yourself a target:** Don‘t leave before you spend at least 10 minutes with at least 7 people
- **Always follow through:** Never leave a loose end



Building an Audience



- **Build Engagement early:** Talk about what you do, find people who are interested
- **Create a brand:** Use social media with memable posts to collect a following
- **Create Virality:** What do people get for forwarding your asks
- **Collect all leads:** Always allow opportunities to leave email addresses
- **Reach out:** Use Newsletters and LinkedIn Mails to get to your users

Remember: Building begins in the problem space!
Your problem needs to be validated before the solution.

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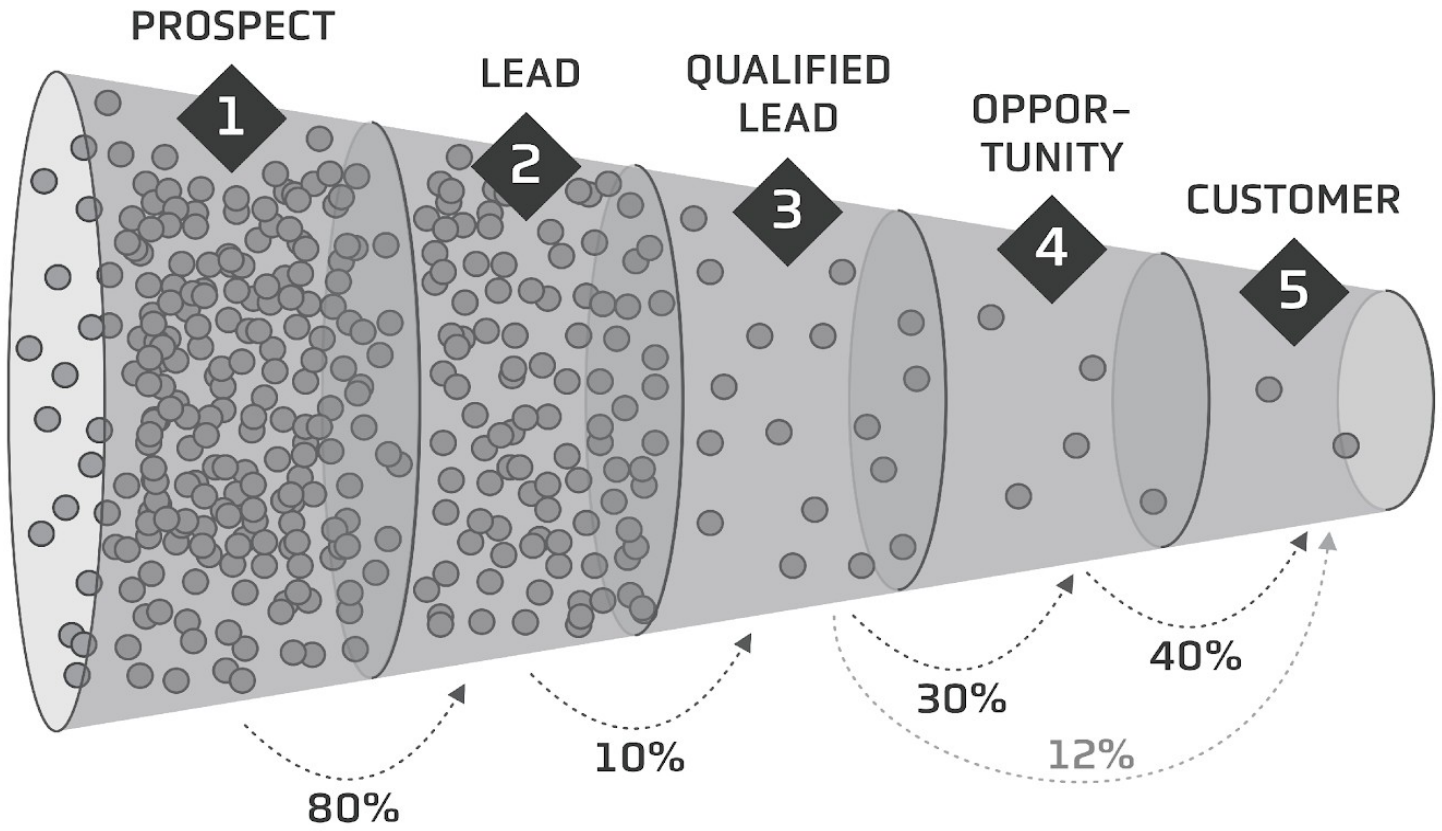
Tool: Interviewing Techniques

Customers

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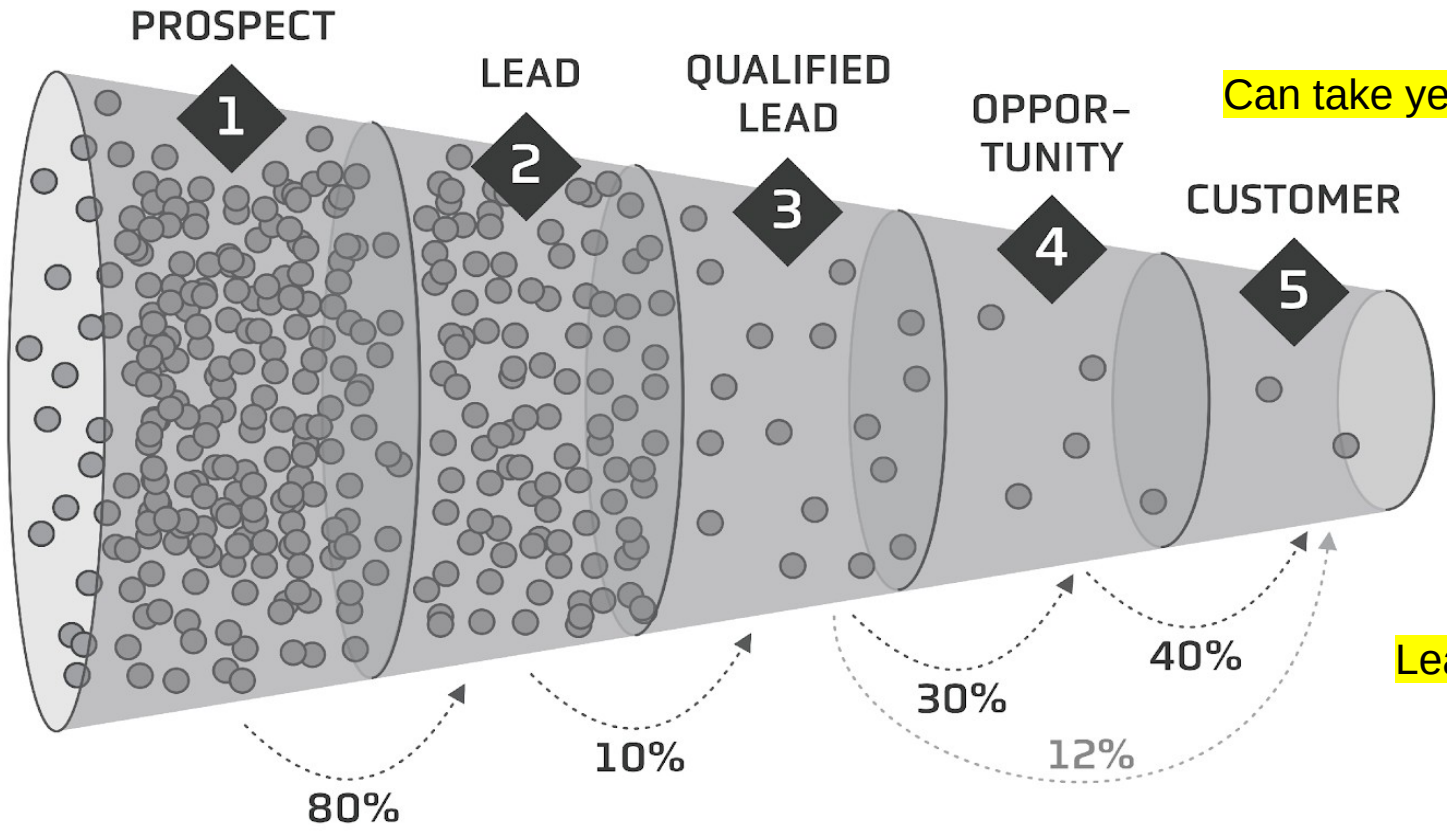
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The Sales Funnel



The Sales Funnel

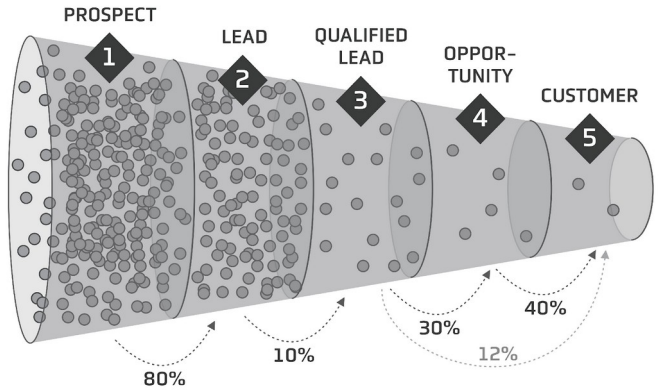
Requires multiple touchpoints

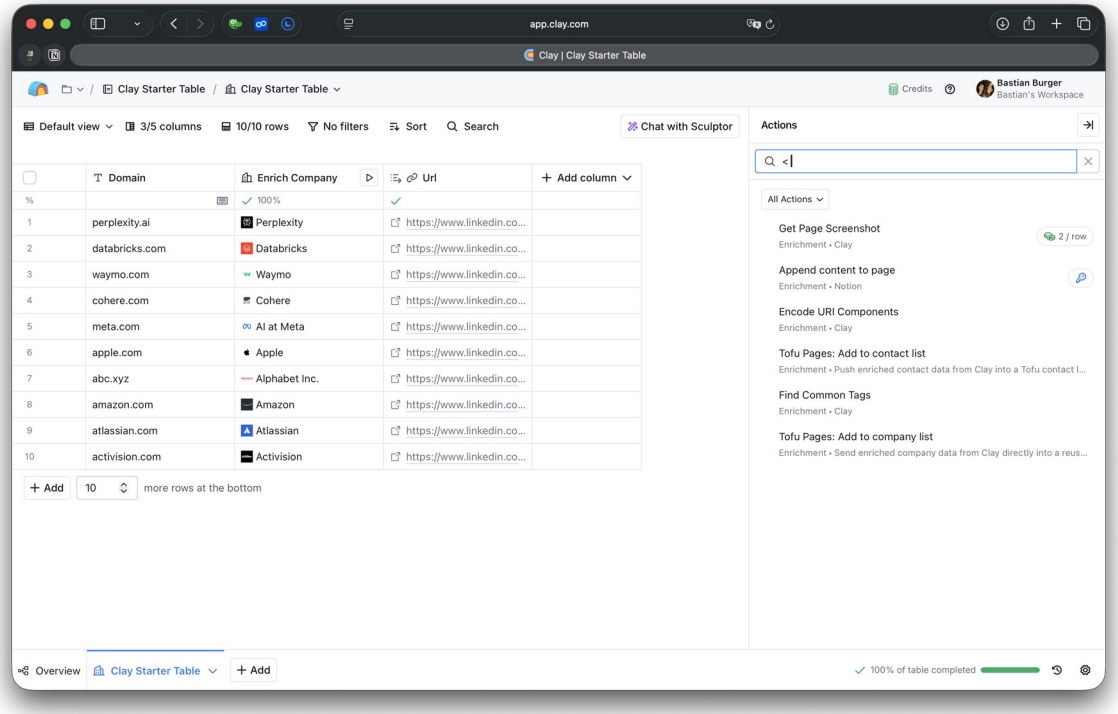


Can take years

Leads can get cold and hot

Finding Prospects





Filter:

Use filters to only have people in your accont that can seriously convert (compare „How to find customers“)

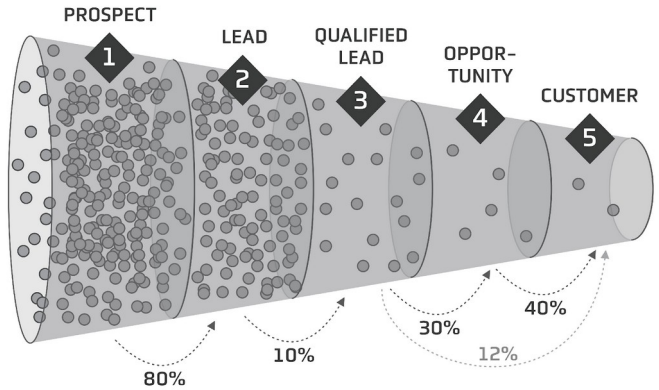
Customer Segment:

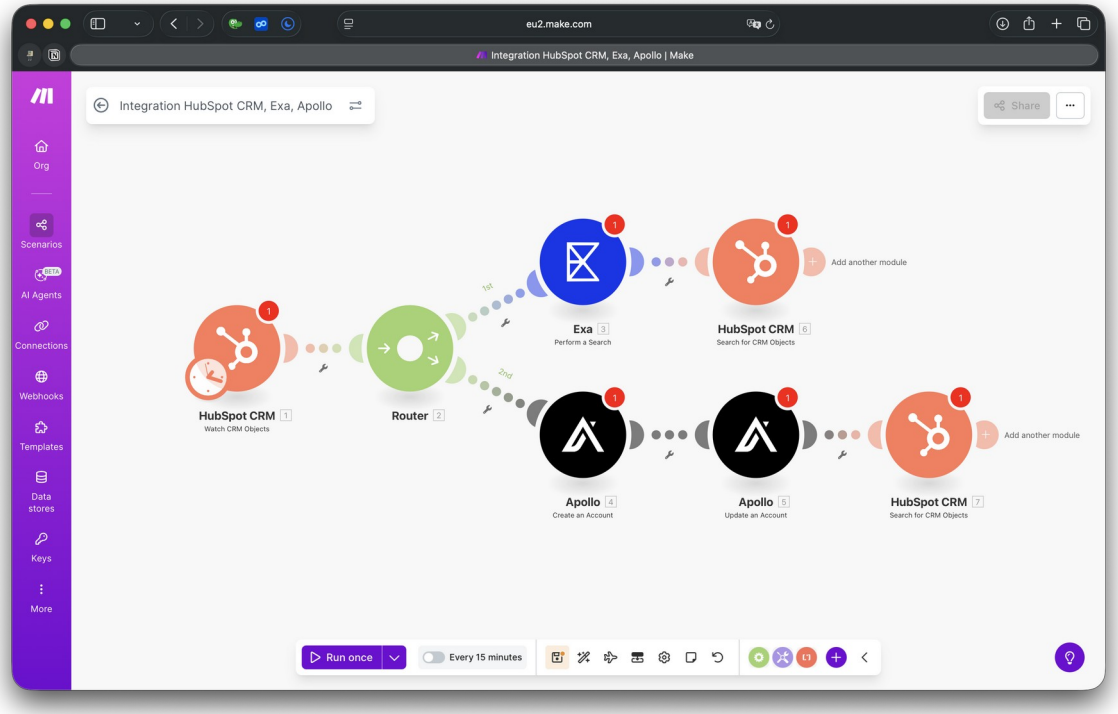
Have your customer segment ready so that an algorithm can decide and find them for you

Inbound/Outbound:

Let the prospects come to you (inbound) or find them proactively (outbound). Inbound has higher success rates.

Generating Leads



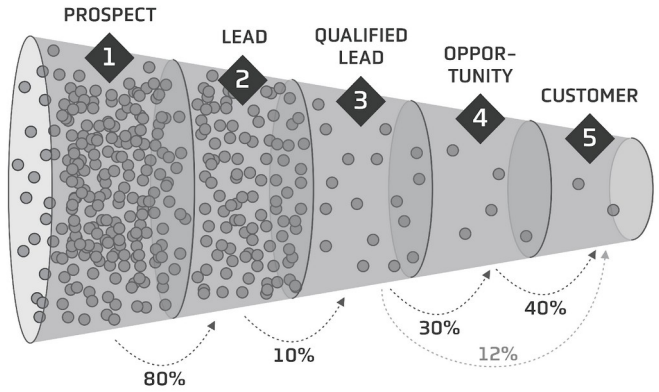


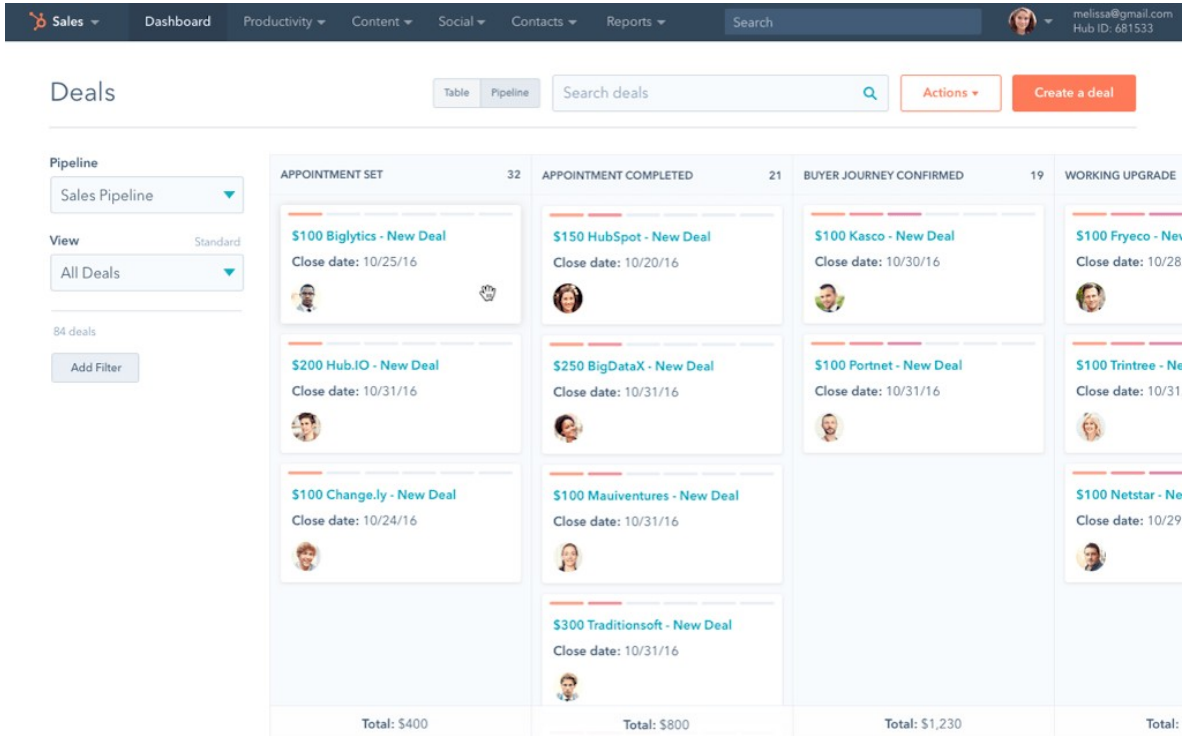
Lead Enrichment:
Use tools or automations that will add information that help you serve your leads best (i.e. email, job position, etc.)

Lead Nurturing:
What can you give the Lead that will get them closer to buying (self-service demo, whitepaper, etc.)

Lead Scoring/Qualification:
What signal do your leads show to make clear they are ready to buy? (i.e. schedule a call with you)

Closing a customer





What is a customer:

Has a signed contract (i). Their money is on your bank account (ii). The ink is dry under the contract (iii).

Opportunities:

Provide them with everything they need to sign the contract.

Customer Success:

Follow your customers closely, to make sure they are happy.

You‘re in luck: You‘re not selling used cars!



As a founder, **you are the first salesperson**

- Sales = **structured conversations** that turn *interest* into *commitment*
- Goal at this stage: **learn + sell at the same time**

→ Use your prototype to test if people will:

- Spend time
- Change behavior
- Eventually spend money
- Sales is not “being pushy” – it’s **helping the right people solve a painful problem**

The Sales Process – Measure & Connect Everything

	1 Prospect	2 Lead	3 Qualified Lead	4 Opportunity	5 Customer	6 Customer Success
Input	Segmentation criteria **and** ICP defined	Individual contact data acquired	Interest validated	Budget, decision-making unit identified	Offer made	Solution successfully implemented
Activity	**Creating company lists, conducting desk research, attending events**	**Outbound: Emailing, calling, sending LinkedIn messages** **Inbound: Contacts through webform, calls, emails, received business cards**	**Emailing, calling Focused product demo**	**Demo & presentation**	**Conducting pilot/trial period** **Negotiating operational contract**	**Retrieving references** **Evangelizing** **Resolving issues** **Negotiating expansion**
Output	Individual contact data acquired	Interest validated Champion identified	Budget, decision-making unit identified Pain points well understood Decision timing understood	Offer made, decision criteria, process & timeline defined	Contract signed	Upsell signed
Entry	Outbound lists	Inbound requests		RFPs & Tenders		

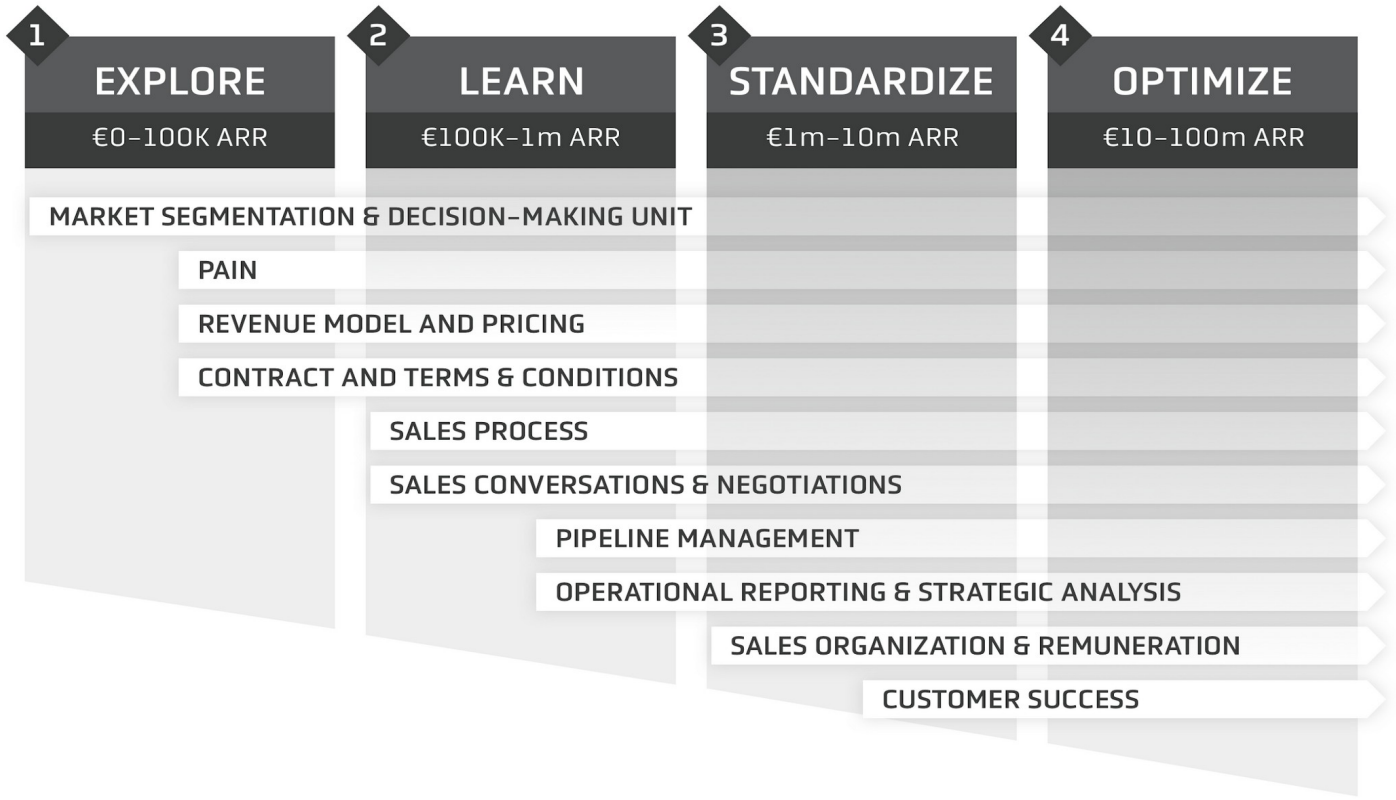
Sales is a long game

Sales is such an essential area of your business. You can’t just hand it off to someone else.

As a founder, you have to go through the process yourself to understand it.

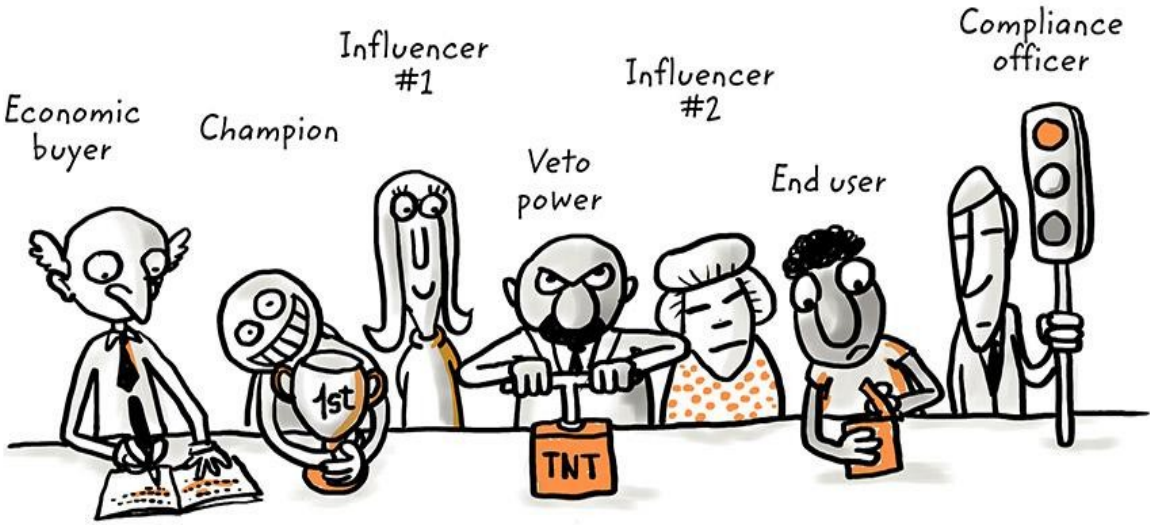
In the beginning, sales is a very entrepreneurial activity. How do you find someone with a need? How do you get their contacts?

— **Bastian Nominacher**
Co-Founder & Co-CEO, Celonis



Understanding your Customer Organisation

- Your **target customer** almost certainly has a **decision-making group** of more than one person.



- **Understanding** this group and explicitly **mapping out each person's role and interest** is critical not just for sales, but also much earlier in the process when you are developing the product and all of its attributes.

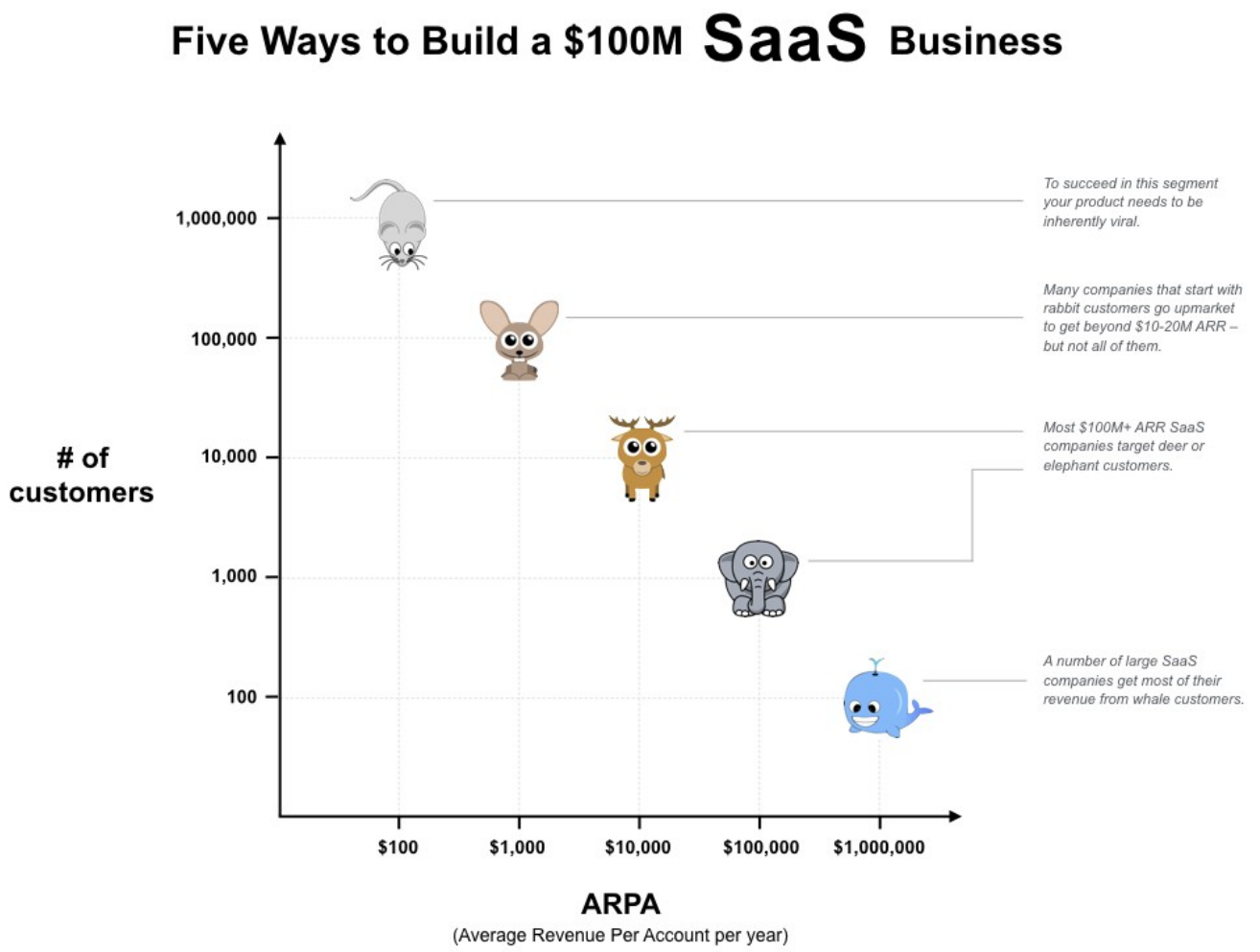
Aulet 2017, p. 140

Finding your buyer

Title	Revenue & budget responsibility	Contract signing capability (Target ARPA)	Marketing message	Involved teams
CEO	€1 billion	€10 million	10 year vision, P&L impact in €, competitive advantage	Board/Shareholders
CXO	€100 million	€1 million	P&L impact in €, competitive advantage	CEO, Purchasing, Legal, IT
SVP/VP	€50 million	€500,000	Competitive advantage, revenue gains, cost efficiency	Purchasing, Legal, IT
Director	€10 million	€100,000	Cost efficiency in €	Purchasing, Legal, IT
Head	n/a	€50,000	Product benefit	Purchasing
Manager	n/a	€1,000	Product benefit	
R&D / Innovation		€25,000-50,000 (pilot only)	Innovation	

*Illustration based on a large corporate client in Germany

Decide on the company you want to build



If it takes you the same time closing 10k or 1m, go for the bigger contracts*

VENTURE LABS

10.000€ ARPA

= small Pilot project turned permanent

Selling performance & features
Need to convince Head of/Abteilungsleiter

➔ 10 contracts add **1M in valuation**

1.000.000€ ARPA

= projects that CEOs usually sign off

Selling vision & new opportunities
Need to convince CEO/Vice President

➔ 10 contracts add **100M in valuation**

*Only applies to B2B businesses

Contract size comparison for a 5.000 employee organisation*

Produkt / Kategorie	Grober Listenpreis	Implied ARPA bei 5.000 Seats
Microsoft 365 E3	~€38/User/Monat	**~€2,3 Mio./Jahr**
Google Workspace (Enterprise-artig)	~€27/User/Monat	**~€1,6 Mio./Jahr**
SAP S/4HANA Cloud (ERP)	~€220/User/Monat	**~€13,2 Mio./Jahr**
Slack Business+/Enterprise Grid	~€15/User/Monat	**~€0,9 Mio./Jahr**
Salesforce Sales Cloud Enterprise	~€175/User/Monat	**~€10,5 Mio./Jahr**
Notion Enterprise	~€22/User/Monat	**~€1,3 Mio./Jahr**
ServiceNow ITSM	~€120/User/Monat	**~€7,2 Mio./Jahr**
Personio HCM	~€38/User/Monat	**~€2,3 Mio./Jahr**
Atlassian Jira (Premium/Enterprise)	~€28/User/Monat	**~€1,7 Mio./Jahr**
Zoom Business/Enterprise	~€18/User/Monat	**~€1,1 Mio./Jahr**
GitHub Enterprise Cloud	~€21/User/Monat	**~€1,3 Mio./Jahr**
Okta Workforce Identity	~€20/User/Monat	**~€1,2 Mio./Jahr**

*i.e. Personio, eGym,Synlab, Rodenstock, Eurowings, MVG, …

HQ DACH: 300
HQ EU: 2.000

You might be 2nd degree connected with 150 C-levels of those.

Antoine‘s tricks

A few (of my personal) tricks 1/6

Prepare, prepare, prepare, …

- Have clear goals for meetings
- BATNA (from Book “Getting to yes”)
- Ensure you can align what you do with the company’s perceived strategy

In particular, prepare the first 5 minutes very carefully, do not improvise

A few (of my personal) tricks 2/6

Avoid the dreaded “I” word

Learn how to use open questions

A few (of my personal) tricks 3/6

LISTEN !!!!!

Watch body language

Ask questions

Key to get a sense of when you can close

A few (of my personal) tricks 4/6

For early stage and big ticket later stage, prefer analog to digital meetings

Set up meetings at 10:30 not 9 or 13:30 …

Always start when calling someone by “is this a good time to speak ?”

A few (of my personal) tricks 5/6

When working with bullies

- Two steps forward, one step backward
- Put yourself in the other guys' shoes

A few (of my personal) tricks 5/6

When working with smart people

- Flattery

A few (of my personal) tricks 6/6

After closing/signing

- Shut up

Workshop: Finding your first 100 users

Workshop Objectives

YOUR GOAL

Create a concrete plan to acquire your first 100 users

By the end, you will have:

- ✓ Your conversion funnel mapped out
- ✓ 3 specific acquisition channels identified
- ✓ Week 1 action plan with targets

Workshop Structure

20 min — **Exercise 1: Map Your Funnel**
Define your conversion stages & estimate rates

25 min — **Exercise 2: Find Your Channels**
Identify where your customers are & how to reach them

25 min — **Exercise 3: Build Your Action Plan**
Create a week-by-week roadmap to 100 users

20 min — **Share & Feedback**
Present your plan to peers & iterate

Your Workshop Tasks

EXERCISE 1

Map Your Funnel

1. How many impressions do you need to get 100 users?
2. What's your expected conversion rate at each stage?
3. Where is your biggest drop-off likely to be?
4. How will you track each conversion step?

Output: Funnel diagram with estimated numbers

EXERCISE 2

Find Your Channels

1. Where do your ideal customers spend time online?
2. Where do they gather offline?
3. Which 3 channels can you test this week?
4. What's your hook/message for each channel?

Output: Channel list with specific tactics

EXERCISE 3

Build Action Plan

1. What can you do TODAY to get 5 users?
2. What's your target for end of this week?
3. Who in your network can help you today?
4. What's your "concierge" approach for first 10?

Output: Week 1-4 action plan with KPIs

Let‘s talk conversion (1/3)



Example Numbers:

47.060 1.600 64

Conversion Rates:

3,4% 4%

Industry Averages:

2-5% 1-3%

How many IMPRESSIONS do you need for the desired number of Sign-Ups?

Sooo: How make numbers go brrr…?

IMPRESSIONS

- Always be posting
- Improve your targeting
- Improve your relevance

Tool: Posting & Outreach

CLICKS

- Farm your friends & family
- Guide through keynotes & presentations

Tool: Keep the flywheel going

Sign-Ups

- Demos, Interviews, …
- Personal Interaction

Tool: Interviewing Techniques

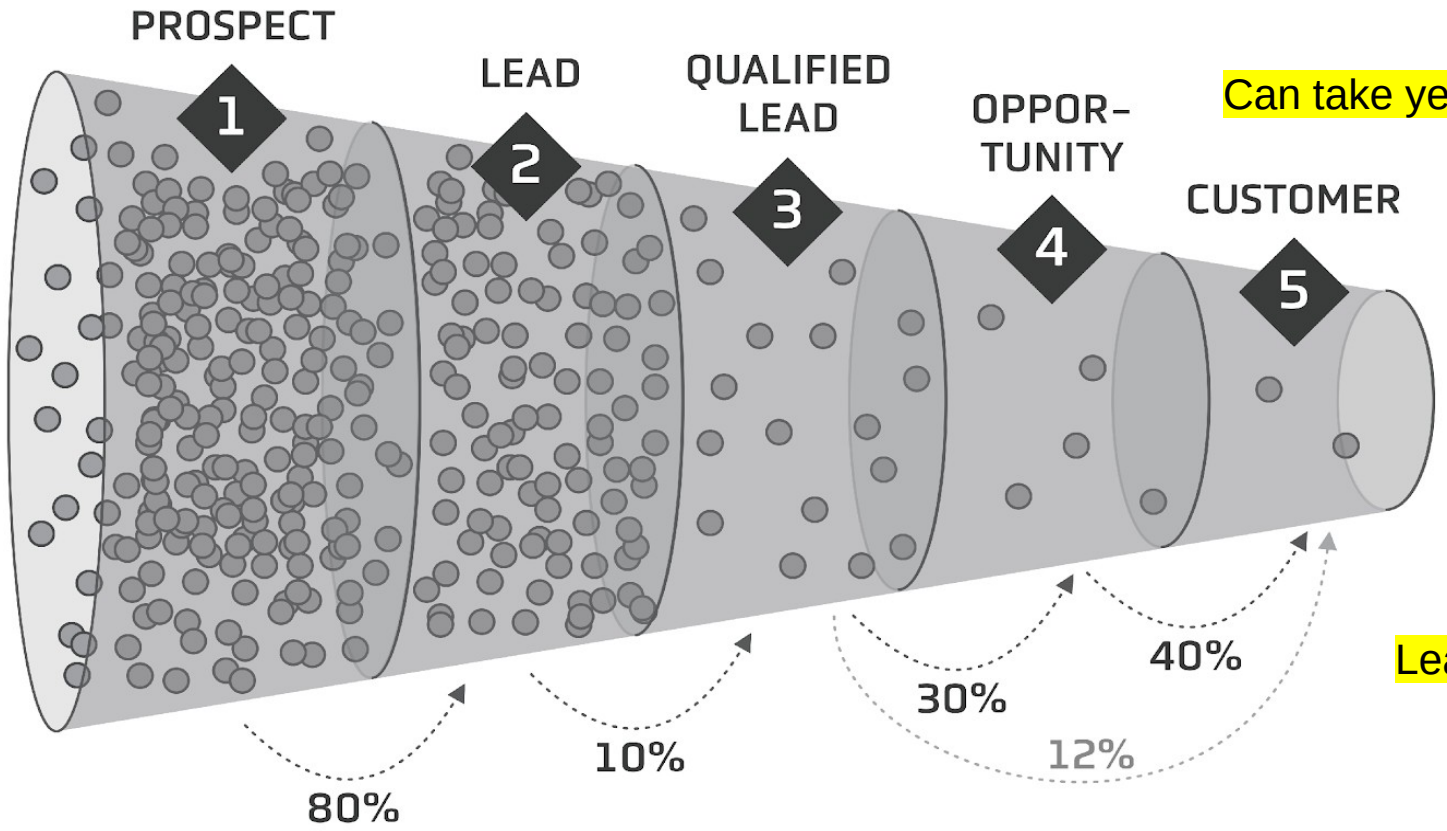
Customers

- Show attention
- Manage your funnel
- Be their concierge

Tool: Managing your Funnel

The Sales Funnel

Requires multiple touchpoints



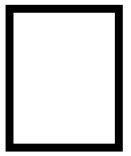
Can take years

Leads can get cold and hot

Reflection 1: The Content – What could you apply

What could you apply?

What gave you a hard time?



Reflection 2: The Process – Man vs. Machine

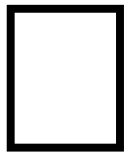
Where did AI actually help you?

Where was your genius needed?

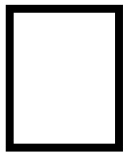
What are your best hacks to share?

Reflection 3: The Results – Rose, Thorn, Bud

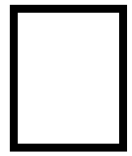
What was the breakthrough today?



What was the hardest part today?



What is an idea/feature you didn't have time to finish, but want to explore later?



Expand your prototype to have around 100 users on it and convert your 1st customer to paying.